

Electronics Surveillance: Successes and Failures



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Surveillance in its various forms and for different situations has been practiced by humans from time immemorial. People used to accomplish this task for themselves and for others as a social obligation or as a paid job.

When unlawful activities like thefts and crimes in the society are growing in an unprecedented and uncontrolled manner, and law-enforcing agencies are finding themselves incapable to cope up with the challenges and smart modes of operandi by thieves and criminals, along with the isolated and indifferent attitude of individuals towards society, the role of electronic surveillance has become indispensable.

The use of electronic or electric methods to keep watch over persons or organisations, termed as physical surveillance, has obvious advantages for the purpose of law enforcement. It is a means to observe suspected individuals in normal, uninhibited states to gather possibly useful information.

Two general categories of electronic communication surveillance exist.

Wire communications refer to the transfer of human voice from one point to another via use of a wire or cable. When law enforcement agencies tap a wire, they use some mechanical or electrical device that gives them access to the communication, thus disclosing contents of the conversation.

Electronic communications refer to the transfer of information, data or sounds from one location to another over a device designed for electronic transmission. This type of communication includes email or information uploaded from a private computer to the Internet.

The techniques of electronic eavesdropping offer the possibility of gathering evidence, which would otherwise be unobtainable.

Interception of wire communications is almost as old as the inventions of the telegraph and telephone. Late nineteenth century witnessed the inventions and uses of microphones, dictograph recorders and hidden cameras to conduct surveillance, usually by private detective agencies. Wire-